

Saronic

Defence Technology · Autonomous Maritime Vessels / Shipbuilding · Austin, Texas · Private (\$9.25B; \$1.75B Series D, Mar 2026)

Saronic, the Austin-based builder of autonomous naval vessels, closed a \$1.75B Series D led by Kleiner Perkins at a \$9.25B post-money valuation on 31 March 2026, more than doubling its price in a year, with the capital pointed at shipyards: a \$300M Louisiana expansion and Port Alpha, then choosing its site.

71

OPPORTUNITY / 100

TIMING WINDOW

HOT

SERIES

F1

RECOMMENDED TEAM

Cadillac F1 Team

ACTION HORIZON

6-10 WKS

THE CASE

On 31 March 2026 Saronic announced a \$1.75B Series D led by Kleiner Perkins at a \$9.25B post-money valuation, with Advent International, Bessemer Venture Partners, DFJ Growth and BAM Elevate joining 8VC, Caffeinated Capital, Andreessen Horowitz, Elad Gil and Franklin Templeton; a \$600M Series C had valued it at \$4B in 2025. In December the US Navy awarded a \$392M production contract for its 24-foot Corsair, prototype to production in under 12 months. Franklin, Louisiana is adding 300,000 square feet and 1,500 jobs; Port Alpha targets 20-plus vessels a year by 2027. **AMERICAN SHIPBUILDING, REBUILT FROM TEXAS.**

No defence, maritime-autonomy or shipbuilding brand sits on the Formula 1 grid; the nearest adjacencies are Boeing at Alpine and Zoox at Williams, and neither conflicts. The question is not a category clash but which team's identity a US Navy supplier can stand behind. Two teams are American: one a privateer built around machine tools, the other a General Motors works entry in its first season with a manufacturing campus rising in Indiana.

WHY NOW

The Series D closed on 31 March and the Port Alpha site decision, with its governors and senators, is the next public act. Cadillac settles its 2027 roster between the summer break and the United States GP in Austin, Saronic's home city; a deal agreed by summer is announced at home.

PROOF POINTS — EVERY FIGURE VERIFIED TO A PRIMARY SOURCE (SEE P.2)

\$1.75B

\$1.75B Series D led by Kleiner Perkins at a \$9.25B post-money valuation, announced 31 Mar 2026; follows a \$...

\$600M

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\$392M

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GRID FIT — CATEGORY-WHITESPACE CHECK ACROSS THE F1 GRID (SPONSOR TABLE; 49 OF 346 PARTNER ROWS CATEGORISED)

Cadillac F1 Team	PRIME LANE	greenfield entry — partner roster being built from zero
Mercedes-AMG Petronas F1 Team	OPEN	no rival in this category lane
Oracle Red Bull Racing	OPEN	no rival in this category lane
Scuderia Ferrari	OPEN	no rival in this category lane

BOTTOM LINE

A \$1.75B Series D at \$9.25B, a \$392M Navy production contract and two shipyards to staff give Saronic the budget and the motive for a national platform. Cadillac is the American works team with no industrial or defence partner, and the United States GP in Austin is home for both.

FUNDING EVENT

OPEN CATEGORY

HOME RACE

DISCOVERY: SCAN

1440 SPORTS · LONDON · VERIFY BEFORE CIRCULATION

SARONIC · 5 MAY 2026

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WHY CADILLAC F1 TEAM

Cadillac is the American works team, in its first season with an inaugural roster: TWG AI, Claro, Core Scientific, IFS, Jim Beam, Tenneco, Tommy Hilfiger, Pirelli and Alpinestars. It has no industrial-technology, defence or autonomy partner. Its cars are engineered at Silverstone while a campus rises in Fishers, Indiana; Saronic is building Port Alpha on the same reindustrialisation story. Austin is the team's home race and Saronic's home city, and a Navy supplier belongs beside the American flag-bearer.

VALUE TO CADILLAC F1 TEAM — MODE B (TECH SERVES THE TEAM OPERATION)

MODE B - halo with mechanics. Saronic's constraint is people: 1,500 hires in Louisiana, 10,000 planned at Port Alpha, and autonomy engineers who could work anywhere. A Formula 1 partnership is a recruiting platform: engineer exchanges between Cadillac's simulation group and Saronic's autonomy team, campus activations around Austin, the team's manufacturing story told beside Saronic's. Cadillac gains an American industrial partner with a national-security audience for its US hospitality, and content from a shipyard building at Formula 1 pace.

DEAL ARCHITECTURE

Entry as Official Autonomy and Shipbuilding Partner. **THREE YEARS**, 2027-2029, through the Port Alpha build-out. Estimated \$4-6M a year. Scope: sidepod placement, Austin, Miami and Las Vegas hospitality for Navy, congressional and state guests, an engineering-exchange programme, and co-produced content on building at speed.

PRIMARY DECISION-MAKER

Dino Mavrookas

CO-FOUNDER & CEO, SARONIC · VERIFIED

Mavrookas, a former Navy SEAL and Vista Equity Partners investor, co-founded Saronic and fronts every raise. Path: Rob Lehman, Co-Founder and Chief Commercial Officer, who owns marketing and sales; Emily Shanklin, Chief Marketing Officer, ex-SpaceX marketing and communications lead; Patrick Depriest, CFO.

OPENING ANGLE

Lead with Austin and the shipyards.

“Dino, Cadillac is the American works team, and Austin is home for both of you. No defence or autonomy brand sits on the grid, and your constraint is hiring ten thousand people. 25 minutes on Formula 1 as a recruiting platform?”

SCORE COMPOSITION

TIMING 15 / 20 Round closed 31 Mar; Austin in October.	CAPACITY 19 / 20 \$1.75B raised at \$9.25B post-money.	BRAND FIT 13 / 20 Sovereignty archetype; defence brand needs care.	URGENCY 14 / 20 Port Alpha site decision; 10,000 hires.	OPS FIT 10 / 20 MODE B halo; recruiting is the mechanism.
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RISKS & COUNTERS

A DEFENCE BRAND ON A CAR Some teams and host markets are wary of weapons-adjacent partners. **Counter:** Lead with shipbuilding, autonomy and jobs; keep Corsair's strike role out of the creative.

NO OPERATIONAL WORKSTREAM Saronic's product does not run in a race team; this is a halo. **Counter:** Make the engineering exchange and recruiting KPIs the contract's substance.

SOURCES — 15 OF 15 LOAD-BEARING CLAIMS VERIFIED

- https://www.saronic.com/team
- https://www.prnewswire.com/news-releases/saronic-closes-1-75b-series-d-at-9-25b-valuation-to-accelerate-a-new-era-of-maritime-autonomy-302729298.html
- https://www.navalnews.com/naval-news/2025/12/saronic-wins-contract-for-corsair-autonomous-surface-vessel-production/
- https://www.navalnews.com/naval-news/2025/12/saronic-expands-its-louisiana-shipyard-with-300-million-investment-to-accelerate-autonomous-ship-production/